DIPLOMA PROGRAMME PRACTICE / HL / SET A

Psychology / Paper 3

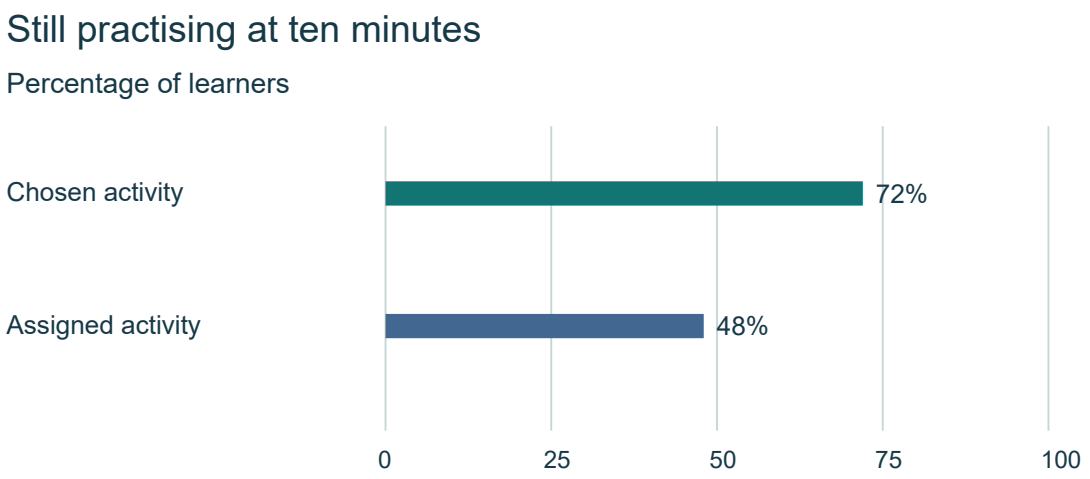
Worked mark scheme · 105 minutes · 30 marks

Answer all four questions. Source 1 appears with Question 1. Use the accompanying resource booklet for Sources 2–5. In Question 4 integrate at least three of Sources 2–5 and your own psychological knowledge.

Judge the whole response against the question-specific markband. Award zero for no creditworthy material. The worked answers illustrate one route; credit other scientifically defensible answers. Class-practical examples are illustrative.

QUESTION 1 / 3 MARKS

Claim for this paper: giving learners a meaningful choice of practice activity increases their persistence. Source 1. Two adult evening classes used different participation rules. Learners in one class chose which activity to practise; learners in the other received a tutor-selected activity. The graph shows the percentage still working ten minutes into an optional practice period. Classes met on different evenings and had different tutors. These research materials are constructed.



Constructed research data.

Explain one issue that limits interpretation of the graph in Source 1.

Worked response. The graph compares existing classes, not learners randomly allocated to the two rules. Tutor encouragement or the kinds of learners able to attend each evening could influence persistence. The difference between 72% and 48% therefore cannot, by itself, be attributed to choice. The figure still describes the difference between the observed groups.

Other valid route. The ten-minute threshold measures persistence at one time point; it cannot distinguish continuing from interest from continuing to please a tutor. Develop one issue in relation to this graph. Identifying an issue alone is worth less than explaining how it constrains the conclusion.

Markband. 1: identify a relevant limitation. 2: describe it clearly in relation to the graph. 3: explain precisely which interpretation it limits and why.

QUESTION 2 / 6 MARKS

Analyse the findings in Source 2 and state a conclusion about the claim that giving learners a meaningful choice increases persistence.

Worked response. The choice group practised for a mean of 12.4 minutes compared with 9.2 minutes when assigned a matched activity. The estimated difference is 3.2 minutes. The 95% confidence interval for the mean difference, 0.8 to 5.6 minutes, excludes zero: the data are compatible with a positive average effect in this setting. It is not the range of differences experienced by 95% of individual learners. The standard deviations also show considerable variation.

Conclusion bounded by design. Random allocation, identical instructions and matched activity frequencies make a pure difference in the activity mix less plausible. Choice may improve fit with an individual's interests as well as perceived autonomy. The design does not isolate those mechanisms. The outcome is voluntary time in this session, supporting a short-run average effect for these volunteers; it does not establish sustained engagement with all schoolwork.

Markband. 1–2: limited or inaccurate reading and a weak conclusion. 3–4: mostly accurate analysis uses some relevant findings and relates a conclusion to the claim. 5–6: detailed, accurate analysis supports a conclusion closely matched to the claim and the evidence.

QUESTION 3 / 6 MARKS

Discuss how the researcher could improve the credibility of the findings in Source 3.

Worked response. The tutor interviewed only volunteers who completed the optional session. They may be especially willing to describe choice positively, and praise may feel safe when a tutor also assesses coursework. Invite learners who stopped early as well as those who continued, and use an interviewer outside the teaching team. Ask for an occasion when choice made practising harder as well as one when it helped.

Interpreting the accounts. An analyst could compare Participant R's account of worry with the theme “choice creates ownership”, document competing interpretations, and invite participants to comment privately on a short account of the themes. Disagreement is evidence to examine, not a vote to erase awkward cases. These changes improve the fit between the interpretation and the range of experiences. They still would not establish how prevalent a theme is in the population.

Markband. 1–2: a relevant qualitative research consideration is recognised but little applied. 3–4: relevant discussion applies it to some features of the source. 5–6: a detailed, accurate discussion uses the particular participants, procedure or accounts to explain its implications.

QUESTION 4 / 15 MARKS

To what extent do the sources support the claim that giving learners a meaningful choice of practice activity increases persistence? Use your own knowledge of motivation and at least three of Sources 2–5.

Worked synthesis. The strongest short-run causal evidence comes from Source 2: the same mix of activities generated 3.2 more voluntary minutes on average when learners chose. Self-determination theory offers a mechanism: a personally endorsed decision can support autonomy. Matching the activity mix cannot separate autonomy from better learner–task fit, and choice can be undermined if every option feels externally controlled.

Integrating different evidence. Source 3 gives the autonomy account texture: one learner wanted to finish a self-chosen route, while another spent time choosing and doubted the decision. Its completion-only interviews cannot tell us how many early leavers felt overwhelmed. Source 4 is consistent with a competence boundary. Among high-confidence learners the return rate is 80% with choice versus 60% with assignment; among low-confidence learners the direction reverses, 40% versus 50%. Self-selection in that source prevents treating those contrasts as treatment effects.

Boundary and judgement. In Source 5 a return advantage seen the next day (68% versus 54%) is almost absent by week four (42% versus 40%). Return on one scheduled day is different from total minutes of persistence. Taken together, the sources support a short-term benefit when choices are understandable and personally meaningful, with weaker support for a durable benefit for all learners. A follow-up varying choice and guidance independently could test whether support for competence changes the effect. Accept another well-defended synthesis built from at least three permitted sources.

Markband. 1–3: fragmented knowledge with limited use of the claim or evidence. 4–6: mainly descriptive reference to the sources. 7–9: relevant evidence and knowledge partly support a conclusion, with uneven integration. 10–12: developed critical analysis combines sources and relevant extension knowledge. 13–15: a coherent synthesis of at least three permitted sources weighs agreement, tensions and limits, uses psychological knowledge precisely and reaches a supported conclusion.